Virtus the Veiled — Mono-Black Deathtouch Drain

Play guide · rebuilt 2026-10-22 · 100 cards, 36 lands · Bracket 3, **3 of 3 Game Changers** (Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor, Tergrid) — at the cap

The commander

> ***Virtus the Veiled*** *— {2}{B} — Legendary Creature — Azra Assassin —* ***1/1***
> *Partner with Gorm the Great · Deathtouch*
> *Whenever Virtus deals combat damage to a player,* ***that player loses half their life, rounded up.***

He is a **1/1**. The half-life trigger does not care how much damage he deals, only that he connects. **Never spend a card pumping him.** Every resource goes into making him unblockable and keeping him alive. Two connections put almost anyone in burn range; from 40 that is 40 → 20 → 10.

Gorm the Great is not in the deck, so the Partner line does nothing. Ignore it.

What the deck actually does

It is not a creature deck that happens to drain. It is a **drain engine** with 26 deathtouch bodies acting as both defence and triggers. Three overlapping plans:

1. **Combo.** A two-card loop that kills the whole table at once. See the next page.
2. **Commander damage by halves.** Virtus or Quietus Spike connecting, repeatedly.
3. **Big black finishers.** Torment of Hailfire for a large X, Exsanguinate, or Gray Merchant of Asphodel off a high devotion count.

The kill — the 2×4 grid

Any **Side A** card plus any **Side B** card is an **infinite loop** that drains every opponent to zero. **Eight** two-card combinations, which is why it assembles so often. Single-target versions still kill the whole table — you choose a new target each iteration, so you kill one player, then the next.

Side A — "whenever you GAIN life"	Side B — "whenever an opponent LOSES life, you gain that much"
Vito, Thorn of the Dusk Rose {2}{B} — target opponent loses that much **Marauding Blight-Priest** {2}{B} — **each** opponent loses 1 **Enduring Tenacity** {2}{B}{B} — target opponent loses that much; returns as an enchantment when it dies **South Wind Avatar** {3}{B} — each opponent loses 1 (and gains you life when your creatures die, so it sparks itself)	**Exquisite Blood** {4}{B} **Bloodthirsty Conqueror** {3}{B}{B} — 5/5 flier with deathtouch These are the only two in mono-black. There is no third; all future redundancy has to come from Side A.

The loop does NOT self-start

Both halves on the battlefield do nothing by themselves. You need **one life-change event** to spark it, and then it runs on its own. This is the single most important thing to know about the deck.

- **Extort** off Crypt Ghast — pay {W/B} on any spell. One mana, the cheapest spark.
- Any lifelink creature connecting.
- A fetch-style life payment, Read the Bones, Night's Whisper, Grim Tutor, Vampiric Tutor.
- **The Darkness Crystal** — any nontoken creature an opponent controls dying gains you 2.
- **Blood Artist** — **any** creature dying anywhere, including between two opponents. Drains and gains in one trigger, so it starts the loop from either side.
- **Ayara, First of Locthwain** — every black creature you cast, and all of yours are black.
- **Aetherflux Reservoir** — every spell you cast, scaling within the turn.
- **Erebos** or **Skullclamp** — any draw you pay life for, refunded by Sheoldred.
- **Tergrid's Lantern** — {T} to make a player lose 3 (or sacrifice, or discard).
- **An opponent attacking another opponent.** Any life loss at the table counts.

> ***Logged 2026-10-21:*** *the loop fired on an opponent's turn, when Collin attacked Douglas with Avacyn for 10. Conqueror gained 10, Blight-Priest drained, and the table died over roughly 38 iterations. The deck did nothing on the turn it won. Final life total 87.*

Evasion — the only thing Virtus needs

Card	What it does for Virtus	Cost
Commander's Plate	+3/+3 and **protection from white, blue, red and green** — every colour not in your identity. Unblockable by any non-black creature, and untargetable by four colours of removal.	{1}, equip commander {3}
Rogue's Passage	Unconditionally unblockable. Works against black decks, which the Plate does not.	{4}, {T}
Dauthi Embrace	Shadow — effectively unblockable, and repeatable on any creature.	{B}{B} per activation
Quietus Spike	A second copy of the half-life trigger that can ride a creature they are less afraid of.	{3}, equip {3}

Protection is DEBT — what it actually stops

Protection from a colour stops four things from sources of that colour: **D**amage, **E**nchanting/Equipping, **B**locking, and **T**argeting. It does **not** stop sacrifice effects, -X/-X, board wipes that say "destroy all", or exile that does not target. Commander's Plate is colourless, so it can still equip a creature it protects.

Black opponents are the hole

The Plate gives no protection from black and black creatures can block through it. Against a black deck, Rogue's Passage or Dauthi Embrace is the answer, not the Plate.

Deathtouch payoffs — read the trigger condition carefully

Card	Triggers on	Needs to connect?
Hooded Blightfang	A deathtouch creature you control **ATTACKS**	**No.** Fires on declaring attackers. Blocking it does not stop the drain.
White Widow, Yelena Belova	Deathtouch creature deals combat damage to a player	Yes
Black Widow, Deadly Hunter	Deathtouch creature deals combat damage to a player	Yes
Arnyn, Deathbloom Botanist	A creature you control with power **or** toughness 1 or less dies	No — it wants your small bodies to trade
Virtus / Quietus Spike	Combat damage to a player	Yes

The Blightfang line is the one that gets misplayed. Attacking with three small deathtouchers drains each opponent for 3 and gains you 3 *before blockers are even declared* — and that lifegain is a combo spark. Attack with everything even into a wall of blockers.

Why the one-mana bodies are in the deck

Hired Poisoner is a vanilla 1/1 deathtoucher and looks like filler. In the logged game it attacked twice and generated **six life of swing** through Blightfang while never dealing more than 1 damage. 26 of 31 creatures have deathtouch; the cheap ones are the engine's fuel, not padding.

Viridian Longbow

Equip it to any deathtoucher and it pings for 1 — which, with deathtouch, destroys anything. Thornbite Staff was cut on 2026-10-22, so the untap lock is gone; this is now one removal activation per turn, not a loop. Add **Basilisk Collar** for lifelink and each kill is also a combo spark.

Skullclamp — your draw engine, added 2026-10-22

Equip {1}, the creature gets **+1/-1**, and when it dies you **draw two**. Six bodies have 1 toughness and die on the spot: Hired Poisoner, Rancid Rats, Foulmire Knight, Tinybones, Vampire of the Dire Moon — and Virtus, who you should **never** clamp. Each death also triggers **Arnyn** (drain 2, gain 2 — a spark), and **Avacyn returns nontoken creatures to the battlefield**, so with her out you draw two and keep the body.

Mana — 29 Snow-Covered Swamps and why

Every basic in the deck is a **Snow-Covered Swamp**. Its type line is "Basic Snow Land — Swamp", so it is still a Swamp for every card that checks, including Cabal Stronghold's "basic Swamp".

Card	Scales off
Cabal Coffers	{2}, {T}: Add {B} for each **Swamp** you control
Cabal Stronghold	{3}, {T}: Add {B} for each **basic Swamp** you control
Crypt Ghast / **Nirkana Revenant**	Whenever you tap a Swamp for mana, add an additional {B} — these stack with each other
Nykthos, Shrine to Nyx	Your devotion to black (77 black pips in the deck)
Urborg, Tomb of Yawgmoth	Makes every land a Swamp, so all of the above count them
Deserted Temple	Untaps Cabal Coffers for a second activation

Extraplanar Lens — imprint on a Snow-Covered Swamp

> *Imprint — When this artifact enters, you may exile target land you control.*
> *Whenever a land with **the same name** as the exiled card is tapped for mana, **its controller** adds one mana of any type that land produced.*

Because your basics are snow, the name it matches is "Snow-Covered Swamp" — which nobody else is running. Imprint it on a plain Swamp by mistake and you double every opponent's Swamps too. **The imprinted land is exiled permanently.**

Liliana of the Dark Realms

Enters at **3 loyalty**, so the −3 kills her the turn you use it. The +1 fetches a **Swamp**, which makes Coffers, Stronghold, Nirkana and Crypt Ghast all better — it is not generic ramp. The −6 emblem gives every Swamp "{T}: Add {B}{B}{B}{B}": ten lands becomes forty mana, which is Torment of Hailfire for X=38. It needs three full turn cycles undefended. **Kaya's Ghostform enchants a creature OR a planeswalker** and is the only protection in the deck for her.

Misplays to avoid

- **Pumping Virtus.** He is a 1/1 and the trigger is half their life regardless. Spend on evasion instead.
- **Forgetting Blightfang fires on attack.** Attack with every deathtoucher even into blockers — the drain and the lifegain happen before blocks.
- **Holding the combo waiting for a "safe" turn.** The loop needs a spark, and sparks come from the whole table. Deploy both halves and let someone else start it.
- **Imprinting Extraplanar Lens on a non-snow land.** That hands the doubling to any opponent running Swamps.
- **Taking the command zone when Virtus dies while enchanted by Kaya's Ghostform.** The replacement is a choice — decline it, let him hit the graveyard, and Ghostform returns him with no commander tax.
- **Using Liliana's −3 as removal early.** It kills her. Only do it if the board demands it or you have already given up on the emblem.
- **Blocking with a deathtoucher and then sacrificing it before damage.** Blocked stays blocked (CR 509.1h) — the attacker deals no damage, but you also deal none, so the deathtouch is wasted unless you needed the body elsewhere.
- **Trying to cast Exsanguinate off Stensian Sanguinist from your hand.** You cannot. It is a **preparation card** — "preparation cards can only be cast with their base characteristics." From hand it is only a {1}{B} 2/2. You get the Exsanguinate copy only after it becomes prepared, which needs the creature it gave deathtouch to **connect**.
- **Pointing Stensian's deathtouch grant at a creature that already has it.** Both it and Hooded Blightfang trigger on declaring attackers, and the grant resolves after Blightfang checks — so it never adds a Blightfang drain. Give it to Vito, Blight-Priest, Gray Merchant, Crypt Ghast or Nirkana Revenant instead.
- **Clamping Virtus.** He is 1/1. Skullclamp kills your commander.
- **Sitting back and never attacking.** Hooded Blightfang fires on **declaring attackers**. Three deathtouchers attacking drains each opponent 3 and gains you 3 before blockers exist — and that is a combo spark. Blocking a deathtoucher is a bad trade for them, so cheap attackers usually get through or trade up.

Opening hand — what to keep

Keep anything with **three lands and a one- or two-drop deathtoucher**. The deck is 36 lands with heavy ritual support (Dark Ritual, Cabal Ritual, Culling the Weak, Bubbling Muck), so two-landers with a ritual and a tutor are keepable. Mulligan hands with no black source by turn two or with three cards costing five-plus.

Tutor priority early: a mana engine (Cabal Coffers or Crypt Ghast) beats a combo half. You find combo pieces faster off a big mana turn than off a turn-three Vito.

Tergrid — the haymaker, added 2026-10-22

> ***Tergrid, God of Fright*** *— {3}{B}{B} — 4/5 Menace*
> *Whenever an opponent sacrifices a nontoken permanent or discards a permanent card, you may put that card from a graveyard onto the battlefield under your control.*
> ***Tergrid's Lantern*** *— {3}{B} — Legendary Artifact*
> *{T}: Target player loses 3 life unless they sacrifice a nonland permanent or discard a card. · {3}{B}: Untap Tergrid's Lantern.*

- **Torment of Hailfire** forces each opponent to lose 3 *unless they sacrifice a nonland permanent or discard a card*. With Tergrid out, **everything they give up comes to you.** X=5 into three opponents can hand you a dozen permanents.
- **Witch of the Moors** makes each opponent sacrifice a creature at your end step whenever you gained life. With Tergrid, you keep all three — every turn.
- The **Lantern** side is a mana sink for flood turns, and the 3 life loss is a spark.

Reference numbers

Deck size	100 — 36 lands (29 Snow-Covered Swamp + 7 nonbasic), 64 spells
Creatures	33, of which **22 have deathtouch printed**
Curve	avg MV 2.77 — 1:15 · 2:15 · 3:16 · 4:10 · 5:6 · 6:1 · 8:1
Black pips	77 — relevant for Nykthos and Gray Merchant of Asphodel
Game Changers	**3 of 3 — Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor, Tergrid. AT THE CAP; do not add a fourth.**
Draw	9 sources — Phyrexian Arena, Black Widow, Read the Bones, Night's Whisper, Village Rites, Profane Insight, plus **Erebos, Ayara and Skullclamp** (all repeatable)
Removal	3 dedicated (Go for the Throat, Snuff Out, Feed the Swarm), plus Witch of the Moors and The Darkness Crystal
Tutors	4 — Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor, Grim Tutor, Diabolic Intent, plus Sidisi

Cards whose text people get wrong

- **Snow-Covered Swamp** is a Swamp. Everything that says Swamp, including "basic Swamp", reads it normally.
- **Extort** triggers once per spell you cast, and you may pay once per trigger. Two extort creatures means two separate triggers on the same spell.
- **Gray Merchant of Asphodel** counts **devotion**, which is black mana symbols on permanents you control — not cards, not Swamps.
- **The Darkness Crystal** replaces an opponent's nontoken creature dying with exile and **gains you 2 life**. That is a combo spark every time one of their creatures dies, and it shuts off their recursion.
- **Witch of the Moors** checks at your end step whether you gained life *that turn*. Any extort payment or lifelink hit turns it on.
- **Torment of Hailfire** gives each opponent the choice each iteration. Against a board full of permanents a small X does very little; it is a finisher, not a value spell.

Built from decks/deathtouch_reference.md. Every card's oracle text re-read from scryfall.db on 2026-10-21.